OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Cr Casmiri Asked to Publish Modelling Behind 'More Customers' Claim

Sent 10 July 2026 · To Cr Casmiri · Response requested by 24 July 2026

Eye on Shoalhaven Council
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10 July 2026

OPEN LETTER — FOR PUBLICATION
Cr Luciano Casmiri
Shoalhaven City Council
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Re: "More Customers" Won't Pay For The Roads
Dear Cr Casmiri,

For well over a year you have offered Shoalhaven ratepayers a simple answer to a hard problem: the city needs "more customers."

More residents, the argument goes, means more rates revenue, and more rates revenue solves what growth itself creates. I am writing to you directly, rather than about you, to give you the opportunity to show the working behind that claim — because on the public record, it has not yet been shown.

This is not a personal complaint. It is a public interest question a reader of this publication could reasonably ask at any ordinary council meeting.

What you have said

This publication reported in August 2025 that you are "fond of saying Shoalhaven needs 'more customers,'" and that you argue more residents "automatically means more revenue." You have repeated versions of that argument since, including in community radio appearances. It is a comfortable story. On the figures Council itself publishes, it is also an incomplete one.

What the record shows

A recently published US white paper on municipal infrastructure — analysing close to 2,000 cities — makes a point that applies just as directly in Shoalhaven:

infrastructure does not stop ageing because a council would rather not pay to renew it. Every road, drain and footpath that is not renewed as fast as it wears out becomes a

hidden financial obligation — invisible on the balance sheet, but just as real as debt.

Shoalhaven already carries a roads renewal backlog of roughly $280 million, a figure this publication has reported from Council's own long-term financial documents, and roads spending has fallen to around 6 per cent of the budget. That backlog is not simply this year's maintenance bill. It is the accumulated cost of past decisions, still unpaid.

Growth does not repeal that arithmetic. Every new subdivision creates new roads, new drains, new footpaths and new street lighting that Council must maintain forever. Developer contributions typically help build those assets once. They do not fund the renewal Council will owe in twenty, thirty or forty years' time. Whether new ratepayers produce a net financial benefit or a net financial liability depends entirely on whether the revenue they generate exceeds the long-term cost of the infrastructure their growth requires. That is a modelling question. It is not a slogan.

You also sit within the governing bloc that told voters in 2024 that fixing the roads would not require higher rates — before imposing a 12 per cent Special Rate Variation, more than double the 4.5 per cent the outgoing council had actually proposed. Residents are entitled to weigh "growth will fix it" against that record.

I am not asserting that you know this argument does not hold up and are making it regardless. I am asking you to publish the modelling behind it, if it exists — or to acknowledge, on the record, that it does not.

Questions

1. What financial modelling supports your public claim that attracting "more customers" to Shoalhaven will fund the infrastructure those new residents require?

1. Council's own roads backlog stands at roughly $280 million and has not fallen while roads spending has dropped to around 6 per cent of the budget. On what basis do you tell residents that growth will fix that, rather than add to it?

1. Do the developer contributions collected for new subdivisions fund only construction, or also the ongoing renewal Council will owe once those roads, drains and footpaths are handed over? What analysis has Council done on that specific question?

1. You have made this argument publicly for well over a year. Will you now publish the modelling behind it, so residents can check the claim rather than take it on trust?

1. If growth alone will not close the backlog, which of the actual funding levers — higher rates, more grants, more borrowing, or reduced spending elsewhere — do you support, and in what combination?

I will publish whatever response is received — including none — in keeping with this publication's standard practice. I would welcome your response by 24 July 2026.

Yours sincerely,
Steve Prothero
Publisher, Eye on Shoalhaven Council

10 July 2026

Note to councillors receiving a copy of this letter: Cr Casmiri has made this argument publicly for well over a year without published modelling behind it. If you believe the numbers do not support it, residents are entitled to hear that from you too — in the chamber, in a Question on Notice, or in your own public comments. A claim repeated without challenge starts to look like consensus, whether or not it is one. This publication will report whatever is raised and whatever is answered.
